

Global Wars & Existential Crises

In *Zero Sum*, wars are rarely about their stated ideological goals. They are the ultimate smokescreens for the Factions, functioning as massive laundering machines, live-fire testing grounds, and tools for societal control.

1. Active Theaters of War

The Eastern European Grind

- **The Public Narrative:** A protracted war for national sovereignty and territorial defense.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** The war is a laundering machine. Western defense budgets are funneled into Eastern oligarch bank accounts through untraceable crypto. Furthermore, it is the premier testing ground for FPV (First Person View) suicide drones and AI-driven targeting algorithms. The front line is effectively an R&D lab for Private Intelligence Factions.

The Middle Eastern Proxy Meatgrinder

- **The Public Narrative:** Ancient sectarian conflicts and proxy wars involving regional superpowers.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** These zones are utilized by surveillance tech companies to beta-test facial recognition software on captive, desperate populations in urban environments. Humanitarian aid is frequently hijacked by PMCs to fund black-ops, and refugee crises are weaponized to destabilize rival European economies.

The Resource Conflicts (Sudan, Myanmar)

- **The Public Narrative:** Tragic civil wars fueled by ethnic tensions.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** These wars are engineered by Sovereign Wealth Syndicates and corporate mega-conglomerates to secure exclusive rights to rare-earth minerals and deep-water ports. The warlords are armed and funded directly by Western and Eastern tech companies.

2. Global Existential Crises

The Climate Collapse as Corporate Strategy

- **The Public Narrative:** A tragic natural escalation of global temperatures, causing unprecedented wildfires, lethal heatwaves, and flooding.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** "Disaster Capitalism." Private intelligence agencies map out climate disasters *before* they happen. They short the local real estate markets, then send PMCs in under the guise of "disaster relief" to violently secure fresh water aquifers and arable land for billionaires' survival compounds.

The Looming Pandemics (Bio-Security)

- **The Public Narrative:** The constant, terrifying threat of a new airborne virus originating from unregulated animal markets.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** The fear of pandemics is aggressively weaponized by the Surveillance State. "Public health mandates" are used to enforce mandatory biometric tracking, DNA harvesting at borders, and digital "health passports" that quietly track associations and limit the movement of political dissidents.

Supply Chain Weaponization

- **The Public Narrative:** Accidental blockages (like the Suez Canal) or natural shortages causing inflation.

- **The Zero Sum Truth:** Algorithmic trading bots intentionally create artificial scarcities of essential goods (microchips, grain, fuel) to spike prices. By controlling the choke points of the global supply chain, factions can bring entire nations to their knees without firing a single shot.